

OFFICIAL PUPIL FIELD COMPANION & STUDY GUIDE

YPRES 1914–1918

The Immortal Salient: Sacrifice, Poetry, Memory & Local Heritage

The War Memorial at Holy Rood Church, Stubbington — Commemorating our village fallen whose graves and memorial panels we visit across the Salient.

TOUR LEADERS:

Mr Ben Lovett (Head of History) & Mr James Garrett (The History Boys)

ACCOMPANYING STAFF:

Dr Kirkup & Mrs Lushey

THE PURPOSE OF OUR JOURNEY: A PILGRIMAGE OF REMEMBRANCE

This field study across the Ypres Salient is not a casual excursion—it is a solemn educational pilgrimage. We journey from our home parish of Stubbington to the ramparts, craters, and sanctuaries of Flanders to walk the ground where a generation sacrificed their youth, and to honour the local sons whose names are carved forever into Holy Rood Church.

*"They shall grow not old, as we that are left grow old:
Age shall not weary them, nor the years condemn.
At the going down of the sun and in the morning
We will remember them."*

— Laurence Binyon, *For the Fallen* (September 1914)

Expedition Dates: 1st–3rd October 2026

Field Base: Peace Village, Mesen

Base Emergency: +44 (0)1329 288339

MASTER EXPEDITION ITINERARY & SALIENT MAP

1st–3rd October 2026 · Three-Day Operational Timetable

FIELD ROUTE
13 Historic Stops



Strategic Overview of the Ypres Salient (1914–1918): Showing frontlines, allied arcs, and major battlefield sites.

EXPEDITION SCHEDULE

DAY / TIME	LOCATION & ACTIVITY	PUPIL FOCUS & KEY ENQUIRY
Day 1 · 06:15	Depart Meoncross School · Folkestone Le Shuttle	Jet Connect coach departure; 11:20 Eurotunnel crossing; arrival in France/Belgium.
Day 1 · 14:30	Stop 1: Essex Farm ADS & Canal Bank	Triage bunkers, McCrae's <i>In Flanders Fields</i> , grave of 15-year-old Valentine Strudwick.
Day 1 · 15:15	Stop 2: Langemarck German Military Cemetery	<i>Studentenfriedhof</i> , 24,917 fallen in the <i>Kameradengrab</i> , Krieger mourning statues.
Day 1 · 16:00	Stop 3: Hoge Crater Museum & Trenches	Underground mine crater warfare, preserved front trenches, and early flamethrower attacks.
Day 1 · 17:45	Arrive Peace Village Hostel, Mesen	Safety briefing, 18:15 dinner, 19:15 classroom debrief (workbook & Medicine question).
Day 2 · 09:15	Stop 4: Vancouver Corner (Brooding Soldier)	First German gas attack (22 April 1915); Canadian heroic stand; gas warfare analysis.
Day 2 · 09:45	Stop 5: Sanctuary Wood (Hill 62) Trenches	Walk original British frontline trenches preserved in deep clay mud (sturdy footwear).
Day 2 · 11:30	Lunch & Snack Shopping (Aldi, Ypres)	Supervised supermarket stop in Ypres; pupils manage budget to buy fresh picnic supplies.
Day 2 · 13:00	Stop 6: Tyne Cot British War Cemetery	World's largest CWGC cemetery; Cross of Sacrifice; locate Stubbington parish fallen on Memorial.
Day 2 · 14:15	Stop 7: Lijssenthoek Military Cemetery	Casualty Clearing Station No. 4; casualty timeline wall; grave of Staff Nurse Nellie Spindler.
Day 2 · 15:45	Stop 8: Passchendaele Museum (Zonnebeke)	Descend 20ft into authentic subterranean dugout system; sensory and psychological immersion.
Day 2 · 19:20	Stop 9: The Menin Gate Last Post Ceremony	Arrive early for 20:00 ceremony; locate Sgt. Frank Rogers (Panel 35); Meoncross wreath laying.
Day 3 · 09:15	Stop 10: Menin Gate Daylight & Ramparts Walk	Daylight panel study; moated Ramparts Cemetery; reading Sassoon's <i>On Passing the New Menin Gate</i> .
Day 3 · 10:30	Stop 11: De Groote's Chocolatier (Grote Markt)	Flemish confectionery craft; €30–€40 cash envelope budgeting; stone-by-stone town rebirth.
Day 3 · 11:20	Stop 12: Talbot House (Toc H), Poperinge	Tubby Clayton's 'Every Man's Club'; 'Abandon Rank All Ye Who Enter Here'; upper room chapel.
Day 3 · 12:45	Supervised Lunch in Poperinge	Lunch stop in Poperinge town centre before afternoon heritage visits.
Day 3 · 13:30	Stop 13: Poperinge Town Hall Death Cells	Physical visit to preserved cells & courtyard execution post; military justice & 2006 statutory pardon.
Day 3 · 14:30	Depart Poperinge · Calais Eurotunnel · Return	Coach departs 14:30 to Calais; 17:50 Le Shuttle crossing; arrival at school approx. 20:00.

📌 ESSENTIAL FIELD GUIDELINES FOR PUPILS

Wear sturdy walking boots and waterproof layers. Keep this guide, a pencil, and your phone in a secure daypack. At each site, listen carefully to staff orientations before beginning your personal observations.

LOCAL HERITAGE: THE LOWRY BROTHERS OF STUBBINGTON

Manor Way Grange · Three Brothers, Three Fronts, Immense Sibling Sacrifice

LOCAL FALLEN
Gallipoli, Somme & Arras

A Family's Total Sacrifice: The Lowry Brothers

William and Annie Lowry lived in a grand twenty-room house called Manor Way Grange in Lee-on-the-Solent. All three of their sons answered the call to arms, serving as commissioned officers in the British and Indian Armies. Tragically, every single son was killed in action across three different battlefronts. Not one of them returned home.



Lieut. William Lowry
8th Gurkha Rifles (Indian Army)

Eldest brother (aged 25); Cambridge scholar. Killed 4 June 1915 leading a desperate charge up Gully Ravine, Gallipoli, under devastating Turkish machine-gun fire.

Body never recovered. Commemorated on the Helles Memorial, Turkey.

📍 **Helles Memorial, Gallipoli**



Capt. Cyril Lowry
2nd Bn, West Yorkshire Regt

Youngest brother (aged 20). Served in same battalion commanded by older brother Eric. Killed 25 March 1918 defending Somme crossing at Eterpigny.

Fell in full view of Eric; body lost in withdrawal. Commemorated on Pozieres Memorial.

📍 **Pozieres Memorial, Somme**



Lt. Col. Eric Lowry
2nd Bn, West Yorkshire Regt (DSO, MC)

Middle brother (aged 25). Commanded 2nd West Yorkshires at Westhoek Ridge and Somme. Awarded DSO, MC & Bar, French Croix de Guerre.

Killed 23 September 1918 by machine gun inspecting outposts near Arleux, dying in runner's arms. Buried at La Targette.

📍 **La Targette British Cemetery (Plot I. C. 2)**

🔍 HISTORICAL INQUIRY: THE CONCENTRATED GRIEF OF SIBLING ENLISTMENT

The tragedy of the Lowry brothers illustrates how the Great War shattered entire households. Rather than casualties spreading evenly across populations, sibling enlistment and Pals Battalions meant that catastrophic losses were concentrated in specific families. How does investigating the Lowrys help us grasp the profound, localized grief experienced across communities like Stubbington and Lee-on-the-Solent?

🏠 LOCAL PARISH CONNECTION: THE LOWRY MEMORIAL HALL & CROFTON TABLET

Devastated by the loss of all three sons, their father William Lowry funded and built the **Lowry Memorial Hall** in Lee-on-the-Solent so his boys would never be forgotten. On the marble tablet inside Holy Rood Church, the three brothers' names are inscribed together in Column 2 under the Army section. Note how their resting places span thousands of miles—from Turkey to the Somme and Arras—yet local parish memorials reunite them forever in their home community.

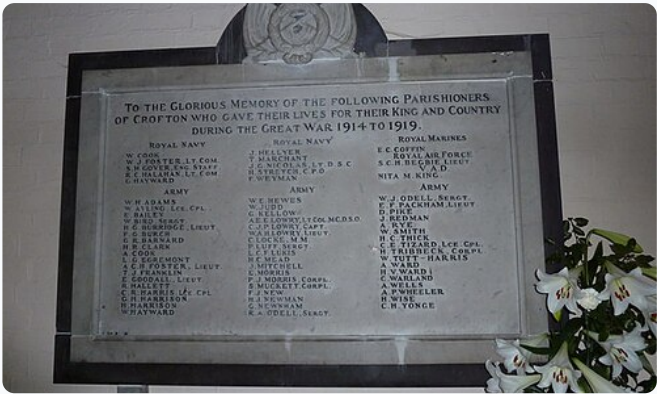
📖 Memorial Record: Stubbington War Memorial Inscription

On the North Beam of the wooden pump shelter in the village square, locate the names: "*LIEUT. W. A. H. LOWRY · CAPT. C. J. P. LOWRY · LT. COL. A. E. E. LOWRY, M.C., D.S.O.*" Reflect on how village memorials served as surrogate tombstones for families whose sons lay in distant or unmarked graves.

The Holy Rood Memorial Roll

The marble memorial tablet inside Holy Rood Church, Stubbington, records the names of men from our village parish who did not return. Six of these local heroes fell directly in the Ypres Salient:

SOLDIER	REGIMENT / UNIT	SALIENT COMMEMORATION
Pte. Walter Spratt	1st Bn, Hampshire Regt	Ploegsteert Memorial (Missing)
Sgt. Frank Rogers	2nd Bn, Hampshire Regt	Menin Gate (Panel 35)
L/Cpl. Arthur Newman	Royal Engineers (Signals)	Tyne Cot Memorial Wall
Pte. George Stares	8th Bn, Hampshire Regt	Bedford House Cemetery
Dvr. Edward Vear	Royal Field Artillery	Brandhoek Military Cemetery
Cpl. Harry Freemantle	Royal Marine Artillery	Dunkirk / Ypres Coastal Sector



The Memorial Tablet inside Holy Rood Church, Stubbington, commemorating our parish fallen.

Parish Pilgrimage Mission: These men walked the same village lanes we walk every day in Stubbington. At each cemetery, we will halt and lay a personal school remembrance cross at their names.

Case Study: Private Valentine Joe Strudwick (Age 15)

Essex Farm · Plot I. U. 8

Valentine Strudwick of Dorking enlisted at just 14 years old, claiming he was 19. Sent to the freezing frontline trenches of the Boezinge Canal bank, he survived months of brutal artillery bombardments before being killed in action on 14 January 1916—one month before his 16th birthday. He remains one of the youngest recorded British casualties in the Great War.

Mother's Chosen Inscription: "Not Gone From Memory, Not Gone From Love, But Gone To Our Father's Home Above."

 HISTORICAL ANALYSIS: UNDERAGE ENLISTMENT & THE 'BOY SOLDIERS'

An estimated 250,000 British boys under the legal fighting age of 19 served in the First World War. Driven by peer pressure, patriotic propaganda, economic hardship, and recruiting sergeants who received a cash bounty of half-a-crown for every volunteer enrolled, teenagers like Valentine Strudwick altered their birth certificates to reach the frontlines. Standing before Strudwick's headstone at Essex Farm, reflect on his age (15) compared to your own life today, and how industrial shellfire wiped out an entire generation before their adult lives could begin.

 Locating Parish Fallen in the Salient

When arriving at Menin Gate, locate **Frank Rogers** on Panel 35 under Hampshire Regiment. At Tyne Cot, inspect the rear stone wall panels for **Arthur Newman**. Notice how individual identification bridges the gap between massive casualty rolls and human memory.

READING THE BATTLEFIELD: GEOGRAPHY & HEADSTONE ANATOMY

The Commonwealth War Graves System · Decoding the Portland Stone Markers

CWGC
ARCHITECTURE
Sir Fabian Ware



Standard CWGC Portland Stone Headstone (81cm high, 38cm wide, 7.5cm thick). Every fallen soldier receives identical dignity regardless of rank.

The 5 Elements of a CWGC Headstone

- 1. Regimental Badge:** Distinctive regimental insignia carved at the top with extraordinary architectural precision.
- 2. Identification:** Service Number, Rank, Full Name, Honours, and Unit. General officers and privates receive identical uniform markers.
- 3. Religious Emblem:** Latin Cross, Star of David, or left intentionally blank for secular or non-Christian soldiers.
- 4. Date & Age:** The exact date of death and soldier's age at the time of sacrifice.
- 5. Personal Inscription:** Up to 66 letters chosen and funded by the grieving family back home.

Unidentified Soldiers: Inscribed with Rudyard Kipling's universal epitaph: "A Soldier of the Great War — Known Unto God." Over 8,300 lie at Tyne Cot alone.

The Geography of the Salient: Why Did So Many Die Here?

A **salient** is an outward bulge in military frontlines, surrounded by the enemy on three sides. British, Canadian, Australian, and French troops defending Ypres were overlooked by German artillery observers on high ground (Messines and Passchendaele Ridges). German gun batteries could converge lethal shellfire from the north, east, and south simultaneously.

Flemish Clay & Water Table: Digging only inches struck water; destroyed drainage dykes turned shell craters into deadly lakes of liquid mud.

Converging Artillery Arcs: Enfilade artillery fire meant no position was safe; heavy explosive shells caused over 70% of all battlefield casualties.

FIELD STUDY FOCUS: ROYAL HAMPSHIRE REGIMENT BADGES & INSCRIPTIONS

As we examine CWGC headstones across the Salient, search for the **Royal Tiger and Hampshire Rose** badge of our local county regiment. Note the personal inscriptions carved at the foot of each stone—chosen and paid for by grieving parents and widows back in Stubbington, Fareham, and Portsmouth. Observe how some express steadfast Christian hope ("Thy Will Be Done"), others classical Roman duty ("Dulce et Decorum Est"), and some profound personal heartbreak: "A Day of Memory Sad to Recall, Without Goodbye He Left Us All."

THE RADICAL EQUALITY OF CWGC

Founder **Sir Fabian Ware** established three non-negotiable principles: (1) no distinction of rank; (2) uniform headstones; and (3) no repatriation, ensuring generals and privates lie together forever in the Flemish soil.

FIELD OBSERVATION HINGE QUESTION

The CWGC charged families 3½d per letter for personal inscriptions, but paid for the stone. Why allow individual family epitaphs while strictly enforcing uniform stone design and banning private crosses?



Concrete bunkers of Essex Farm ADS dug into the canal embankment.

Advanced Dressing Station (ADS): Frontline triage post where surgeons worked by candlelight treating catastrophic wounds. John McCrae penned *In Flanders Fields* here on 3 May 1915.



Lt. Col. John McCrae

1872–1918 • Canadian Army Medical Corps

Physician and soldier from Guelph, Ontario. Served as brigade surgeon during Second Ypres. Penned his famous poem in the back of an ambulance on 3 May 1915 following the funeral of his friend Lt. Alexis Helmer. Died of pneumonia in France in 1918.

In Flanders Fields

BY LT. COL. JOHN MCCRAE • COMPOSED AT ESSEX FARM, 3 MAY 1915

*In Flanders fields the poppies blow
Between the crosses, row on row,
That mark our place; and in the sky
The larks, still bravely singing, fly
Scarce heard amid the guns below.*

*We are the Dead. Short days ago
We lived, felt dawn, saw sunset glow,
Loved and were loved, and now we lie,
In Flanders fields.*

*Take up our quarrel with the foe:
To you from failing hands we throw
The torch; be yours to hold it high.
If ye break faith with us who die
We shall not sleep, though poppies grow
In Flanders fields.*

MEDICAL TRIAGE ANALYSIS: THE CHAIN OF EVACUATION

Essex Farm operated as an Advanced Dressing Station (ADS) cut directly into the canal bank, mere hundreds of yards behind frontline communication saps. Medical officers performed desperate emergency triage—arresting catastrophic hemorrhages, applying field splints, and administering morphine—before stretcher-bearers evacuated wounded men in horse-drawn or motor ambulances to Casualty Clearing Stations (CCS) at Brandhoek and Base Hospitals on the French coast.

STOP 2 ARCHAEOLOGICAL INSIGHT: YORKSHIRE TRENCH RESTORATION

Discovered by amateur Belgian archaeologists ('The Diggers') in 1992 in an expanding industrial zone, Yorkshire Trench preserves original 1915 British frontlines. Notice the timber A-frames supporting duckboards above waterlogged clay, recessed fire-steps, and the deep entrance shafts to the 1917 dugout shelter deep below the water table.

The Somber Atmosphere of Langemarck

Langemarck stands in powerful contrast to the white Portland stone of CWGC cemeteries. Known as the *Studentenfriedhof*, it commemorates thousands of student volunteers fallen in autumn 1914.

Kameradengrab (Comrades' Grave): 24,917 German soldiers buried together in a single mass burial.

Emil Krieger's Statues: Four bronze mourning soldiers standing sentinel beneath towering oak trees.



Charles Hamilton Sorley

1895–1915 • Captain, 7th Suffolk Regiment

Scottish poet born in Aberdeen; educated at Marlborough and Oxford. Lived in Germany before the war and admired German culture. Killed by a sniper at the Battle of Loos on 13 October 1915, aged 20. His stark sonnet was recovered from his kitbag after his death, stripping away patriotic vanity.

When You See Millions of the Mouthless Dead

BY CHARLES HAMILTON SORLEY • FOUND IN HIS KITBAG, OCTOBER 1915

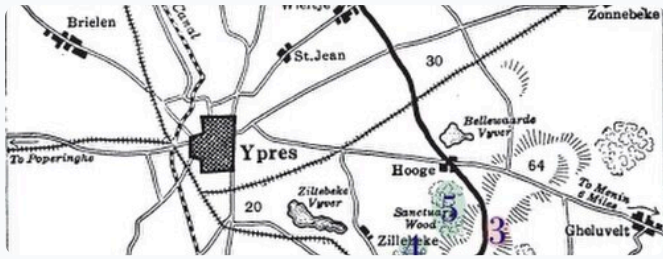
*When you see millions of the mouthless dead
Across your dreams in pale battalions go,
Say not soft things as other men have said,
That you'll remember. For you need not so.
Give them not praise. For, deaf, how should they know
It is not curses heaped on each gashed head?
Nor tears. Their blind eyes see not your tears flow.
Nor honour. It is easy to be dead.
Say only this, "They are dead." Then add thereto,
"Yet many a better one has died before."
Then, scanning all the o'ercrowded mass, should you
Perceive one face that you loved heretofore,
It is a spook. None wears the face you knew.
Great death has made all his for evermore.*

COMPARATIVE HISTORIOGRAPHY: GERMAN VS COMMONWEALTH COMMEMORATION

Notice the stark architectural contrast between Langemarck and Commonwealth cemeteries. Whereas British CWGC sites celebrate radical individual equality with white Portland stone and manicured English cottage borders, the German War Graves Commission utilized dark volcanic basalt, collective mass graves (the *Kameradengrab* holding 24,917 men), and sheltering oak trees to express communal tragedy, somber defeat, and the heavy weight of national grief.

THE MYTH OF LANGEMARCK: PROPAGANDA VS REALITY

German wartime communiqués claimed thousands of young student volunteers charged across the beet fields towards British lines singing "*Deutschland über alles*". In reality, untrained youths were sent forward in dense columns directly into devastating British rapid rifle fire (the 'Old Contemptibles'). Interwar propagandists mythologized their slaughter as heroic self-sacrifice.



The Hooze Crater site: Where underground mines blew massive chasms in the ridge.



Isaac Rosenberg

1890–1918 • Private, King's Own Royal Lancaster Regt

Working-class Jewish painter and poet from Whitechapel; studied at the Slade School of Art. Enlisted in a 'Bantam' battalion (for men under 5ft 3in). Wrote visceral poetry on scraps of cardboard in Flemish mud. Killed in action near Arras on 1 April 1918 during the German Spring Offensive.

Break of Day in the Trenches

BY ISAAC ROSENBERG • WRITTEN IN FLANDERS MUD, JUNE 1916

*The darkness crumbles away.
It is the same old druid Time as ever,
Only a live thing leaps on my hand,
A queer, sardonic rat,
As I pull the parapet's poppy
To stick behind my ear.
Droll rat, they would shoot you if they knew
Your cosmopolitan sympathies,
Now you have touched this English hand
You will have the same chance for a German...
Poppies whose roots are in man's veins
Drop, and are ever dropping;
But mine in my ear is safe—
Just a little white with the dust.*

⚡ TECHNOLOGICAL REVOLUTION: GAS WARFARE & UNDERGROUND MINING

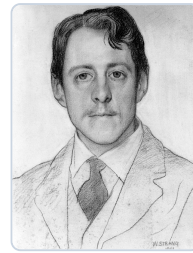
The Ypres Salient served as the terrifying testbed of modern industrial warfare. At Vancouver Corner on 22 April 1915, the German Army released 168 metric tons of chlorine gas, creating a deadly green cloud four miles wide that devastated Algerian and French colonial divisions before Canadian units heroically plugged the breach. At Hooze Crater, British tunneling companies dug hundreds of feet beneath German lines to detonate enormous ammonal mine charges, forever transforming the ridge.

🍁 STOP 4 FOCUS: VANCOUVER CORNER & 'THE BROODING SOLDIER'

Sculpted by Frederick Chapman Clemesha, the 33-foot granite bust of *The Brooding Soldier* towers over Vancouver Corner with hands resting on reversed arms and head bowed in solemn grief. It honors 2,000 Canadians of the 1st Canadian Division who fell holding the frontline during the world's first large-scale chemical weapons attack.



The Cross of Sacrifice erected atop a captured German pillbox at Tyne Cot.



Laurence Binyon

1869–1943 • British Museum Curator & Red Cross Orderly

Scholar of art and poetry who volunteered as a hospital orderly in France in 1916 caring for wounded soldiers. Wrote *For the Fallen* while sitting on the cliffs of North Cornwall in September 1914. Its central stanza was adopted across the English-speaking world as the universal Ode of Remembrance.

The Largest Commonwealth Cemetery: 11,961 soldiers lie buried here, 8,369 of them unidentified. Architect Sir Herbert Baker incorporated three captured German machine-gun pillboxes directly into the cemetery.

For the Fallen (The Ode of Remembrance)

BY LAURENCE BINYON • SEPTEMBER 1914 • RECITED NIGHTLY AT THE MENIN GATE

*With proud thanksgiving, a mother for her children,
England mourns for her dead across the sea.
Flesh of her flesh they were, spirit of her spirit,
Fallen in the cause of the free.*

*Solemn the drums thrill: Death august and royal
Sings sorrow up into immortal spheres,
There is music in the midst of desolation
And a glory that shines upon our tears.*

*They shall grow not old, as we that are left grow old:
Age shall not weary them, nor the years condemn.
At the going down of the sun and in the morning
We will remember them.*

ARCHITECTURAL SYMBOLISM: THE CROSS OVER THE PILLBOX

While **Sir Reginald Blomfield** designed the universal CWGC Cross of Sacrifice pattern, cemetery architect **Sir Herbert Baker** made the inspired decision to site Tyne Cot's great Portland stone Cross directly atop a captured German concrete machine-gun bunker in the centre of the cemetery. The bronze broadsword points downward upon the captured pillbox, symbolizing the ultimate triumph of sacrifice and peace over instruments of war. Along the sweeping curved flint memorial wall behind the cross, Baker had carved the names of 34,984 soldiers with no known grave who fell in the catastrophic mud of Passchendaele.

STUBBINGTON PARISH FALLEN AT TYNE COT: L/CPL ARTHUR NEWMAN

Locate Panel 8 on the Memorial Wall for **Lance Corporal Arthur Newman** (Royal Engineers 153rd Field Company), born and raised in Stubbington. He fell during the Third Battle of Ypres. Like thousands of his comrades, his body was swallowed by the Passchendaele quagmire and never found. Reflect on how this wall restores his name to perpetual memory.



The Menin Gate Memorial: Designed by Sir Reginald Blomfield, inaugurated in 1927.



Siegfried Sassoon

1886–1967 • Captain, Royal Welch Fusiliers (MC)

Decorated for reckless courage ("Mad Jack"), Sassoon became the foremost soldier-critic of the war. Attending the 1927 dedication of the Menin Gate, he reacted with fury against its triumphalist architecture, believing its classical grandeur sanitized the brutal slaughter of the dead.

The Gateway to Battle: Through this eastern gate hundreds of thousands marched towards the frontline trenches. Carved into its stone panels are 54,395 soldiers missing in the Salient prior to 16 August 1917.

On Passing the New Menin Gate

BY SIEGFRIED SASSOON • WRITTEN UPON THE MEMORIAL'S UNVEILING, 1927

*Who will remember, passing through this Gate,
The unheroic Dead who fed the guns?
Who shall absolve the foulness of their fate,—
Those doomed, conscripted, unvictorious ones?
Crudely renewed, the Salient holds its own.
Paid are its expenses by alone
The unknown dead who face the gaping void.
Here was the world's worst wound. And here with pride
'Their name liveth for ever,' the Gateway claims.
Was ever an immolation so belied
As these intolerably nameless names?
Well might the Dead who struggled in the slime
Rise and deride this sepulchre of crime.*

🕯 THE DAILY ACT OF REMEMBRANCE: THE MENIN GATE TRADITION

Every evening at exactly 20:00, traffic halts completely beneath the Menin Gate as buglers from the Ypres Volunteer Fire Brigade sound the *Last Post*. Initiated in 1928, this solemn act of gratitude has continued unbroken through the decades (interrupted only during German WWII occupation, when it was sounded in Surrey, England). As the bugle notes reverberate beneath the vaulted arch bearing 54,395 names of the missing, consider Siegfried Sassoon's bitter protest against glorification alongside Laurence Binyon's eternal pledge: "We will remember them."

🌸 MEONCROSS SCHOOL WREATH LAYING CEREMONY PROTOCOL

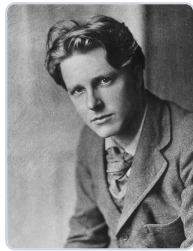
At 19:45, our designated student wreath-bearers will take their positions under the central vault alongside staff. When invited forward by the master of ceremonies, step in unison, place the poppy wreath upon the plinth on behalf of Meoncross School and the parish of Stubbington, take two paces back, and bow heads in silent remembrance.



The Cloth Hall, Ypres (1919): Watercolour by Scottish war artist **Emily Murray Paterson RSW (1855–1934)**, painted on-site amidst the ruins after the Armistice (Imperial War Museum collection).



Talbot House Façade, Poperinge: The exterior façade on Gasthuisstraat, opened in December 1915 by Rev. Philip 'Tubby' Clayton as an unranked sanctuary for all soldiers behind the lines.



Rupert Brooke

1887–1915 · Sub-Lieutenant, Royal Naval Division

Cambridge scholar whose handsome charisma and patriotic sonnets captivated the nation in 1914. Brooke captured the early Edwardian idealism before trench warfare set in. Died of sepsis on a hospital ship off Skyros on 23 April 1915 on his way to Gallipoli.

The Soldier

BY RUPERT BROOKE · WRITTEN LATE 1914

*If I should die, think only this of me:
That there's some corner of a foreign field
That is for ever England. There shall be
In that rich earth a richer dust concealed;
A dust whom England bore, shaped, made aware,
Gave, once, her flowers to love, her ways to roam;
A body of England's, breathing English air,
Washed by the rivers, blest by suns of home.*

*And think, this heart, all evil shed away,
A pulse in the eternal mind, no less
Gives somewhere back the thoughts by England
given;
Her sights and sounds; dreams happy as her day;
And laughter, learnt of friends; and gentleness,
In hearts at peace, under an English heaven.*

SOCIAL HISTORY & REBIRTH: THE SANCTUARY OF TOC H

In Poperinge, Rev. Philip 'Tubby' Clayton opened Talbot House in December 1915 with an extraordinary rule: *"All rank abandon, ye who enter here."* Officers and privates drank tea together, played piano, and climbed to the upper hop-loft chapel for quiet communion behind the lines. Following the Armistice, Winston Churchill advocated preserving the shattered Cloth Hall of Ypres as a permanent ruins monument, but the Flemish citizens chose to painstakingly reconstruct their medieval city brick by brick, symbolising enduring resurrection.

THE UPPER ROOM: THE 'HOP-LOFT' CHAPEL

Climbing the steep attic stairs of Talbot House, soldiers found a sanctuary made from an old carpenter's bench converted into an altar, illuminated by candles in brass shell-casings. Over 100,000 men took communion here before moving up the Menin Road. Inscribed on the wall: *"All rank abandon ye who enter here."*

Trench & Military Terminology

ADS	Advanced Dressing Station: Frontline medical bunker behind trenches for urgent triage before casualty evacuation.
A-Frames	A-shaped timber frames supporting duckboard walkways above waterlogged trench mud.
Pillbox	Reinforced concrete machine gun bunker built by German forces to withstand heavy artillery shellfire.
Salient	A bulge in military lines surrounded by the enemy on three sides, exposed to converging artillery arcs.
Sump	A deep drainage pit dug beneath trench duckboards to catch pooling rainwater.
Trench Foot	Severe fungal and circulatory condition caused by prolonged immersion in cold, wet mud.

CWGC & Memorial Terminology

CWGC	Commonwealth War Graves Commission: Founded 1917 by Fabian Ware to care for 1.7 million fallen.
Cross of Sacrifice	Designed by Sir Reginald Blomfield: Portland stone cross bearing a bronze broadsword.
Stone of Memory	Designed by Sir Edwin Lutyens: altar-like stone carved with Kipling's phrase <i>"Their Name Liveth For Evermore"</i> .
Kameradengrab	German 'Comrades' Grave': a central mass burial holding thousands of fallen soldiers (e.g. 24,917 at Langemarck).
Portland Stone	Fine white limestone from Dorset, chosen for its luminosity and radical equality across all military ranks.

🏳️ CHRONOLOGY: THE FIVE BATTLES OF THE YPRES SALIENT (1914–1918)

BATTLE	DATES	KEY HISTORICAL SIGNIFICANCE & OUTCOME
First Ypres	Oct – Nov 1914	BEF and French halt German 'Race to the Sea'. Traditional regular British Army largely decimated.
Second Ypres	Apr – May 1915	First mass use of poison gas (chlorine). Canadian Division holds line at St. Julien. Salient compresses.
Battle of Mount Sorrel	June 1916	Fierce fighting around Hill 62; Canadian Corps retakes strategic vantage points overlooking Ypres.
Third Ypres (Passchendaele)	July – Nov 1917	Catastrophic offensive in torrential rain and liquid mud; over 500,000 casualties for five miles of advance.
Battle of the Lys & Advance	Apr & Sep 1918	German Spring Offensive stopped; Allied Hundred Days Advance liberates the Salient permanently.

Useful Flemish & French Toponyms in the Salient

Ieper: Ypres	Poperinge: "Pop" (rear town)	Heuvelland: Hill country (hostel)	Menenpoort: Menin Gate
Lakenhalle: Cloth Hall	Krombeke: Reserve lines	Zonnebeke: Polygon Wood area	Mesen: Messines Ridge

📌 CODE OF CONDUCT & PUPIL EXPEDITION STANDARDS

- Quiet Respect:** Cemeteries are active places of international mourning. Walk strictly on grass paths; never sit on headstones.
- Mobile Phone Protocol:** Phones may be used for educational photography during visits. Collected into secure bags at evening curfew.
- Hostel Downtime:** Quiet hours from 22:00 at Peace Village. Respect other international student groups.
- Ambassadors of Meoncross:** We represent our school and the village of Stubbington before the people of Flanders.

Expedition Staff: Mr Ben Lovett & Mr James Garrett (Tour Leaders) · Dr Kirkup & Mrs Lushey (Accompanying Staff)

School Base 24/7 Emergency: **+44 (0)1329 288339**